

A Ninja Doesn't Trip On His Shoelaces

Running on walls, leaping buildings with your grappling hook, stealth kills—who would have thought you could do this on the PSP? *Shinobido: Tales of the Ninja* takes you through to 16th-century Japan, where you play Goh, the last Ninja, out for revenge against those who wiped out his kin. This revenge involves stealing documents, assassinations, and some gratuitous murder. And you know how much you love gratuitous murder.

The game's controls are rather clunky, and mar an otherwise enjoyable game. Fighting enemies is all about mashing a single button and hoping to hit home, and the "lock to target" scheme can goof up considerably if you're fighting two or more of them. Camera angles are all wonky, and a second analogue stick is sorely missed. The missions are designed to get over quickly, though—perfect for playing on the move.

Overall, pulling off stunts and stealth kills is fun—especially in the "Total Destruction" missions, but there's really nothing about this game that screams, "Buy me!"

nimish_chandiramani@thinkdigit.com



Tales of the Ninja (PSP)

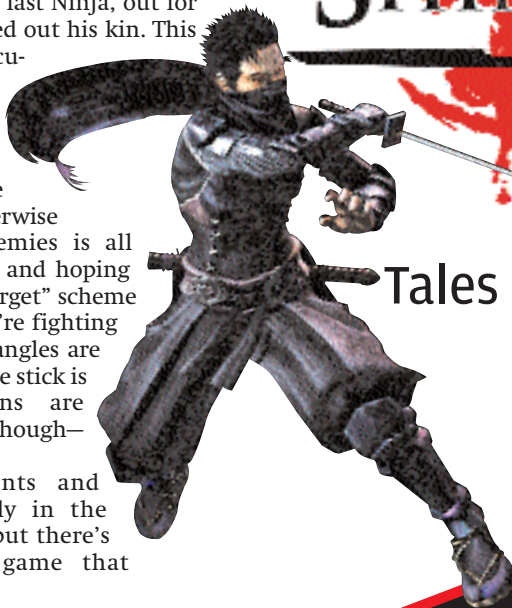
Rating: 6/10

Developer: Acquire

Publisher: Sony Computer Entertainment Europe

Distributor: Milestone Interactive

Contact: sales@milestoneinteractive.com



KILLZONE LIBERATION



Rating: 9/10

Developer: Guerilla

Publisher: SCEA

Distributor: Milestone Interactive

Contact: sales@milestoneinteractive.com



Sony's PSP inherits *Killzone Liberation*, of 2004 *Killzone* fame, a PS2 shooter. *Killzone's* gameplay was seriously lacking. While *Liberation* inherits the storyline, the gameplay deviates—a good thing!

For those unfamiliar with the *Killzone* universe: mankind's taken to the heavens, inhabiting planets and such. A militant group of humans occupy a planet called Helghan. Over time, these guys mutate into a race called the Helghast. Flashback over, you belong to the *other* group a.k.a. the Vekta, humans who are fighting against the, umm, Helghast.

At the outset, *Liberation* doesn't follow a very sharp storyline; there's VIPs to be rescued, and a pesky Helghast general who keeps messing up your plans. Normally this would translate into a game 15 minutes with which would cause you to yell "next!" After all, how redeeming could gameplay and eye-candy be on the PSP, and can it make up for an ordinary story? In a word, emphatically, yes! Gameplay is excellent. *Liberation* grips you, then makes a believer of you. The graphics engine is very good, though not the best I've seen on the platform. Audio's up there—superb in-game sound and good voice acting.

You'll deactivate trip lasers, snipe bots, man turrets, crunch Helghan bone beneath your tank treads, and even control non-player characters—all while completing your mission objectives. In each mission you'll collect Vectan, the currency of the *Killzone* world, and buy weapon upgrades. You'll also unlock player abilities—carrying five grenades instead of the default two, or increased health and armour. AI is very sharp... enemies will duck behind cover when you shoot at them, only to pop up and snipe at you. Needless to say, you'll end up dead quite a few times. Thankfully, the autosave works well and is aptly-timed.

Killzone Liberation is a great deal of fun, and immersive, action-laden gameplay coupled with great video and excellent audio.

michael_browne@thinkdigit.com